

Gayane Baghumyan

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Research Interests

Behavioral and Experimental Economics; Discrimination, Identity, Motivated Reasoning

References

Michal Bauer (Advisor)
Professor of Economics
CERGE-EI
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John List
Griffin Distinguished Service Professor of
Economics
University of Chicago
jlist@uchicago.edu

Andreas Ortmann
Professor of Experimental and Behavioral
Economics
UNSW Business School
a.ortmann@unsw.edu.au

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, CERGE-EI / Charles University, Prague *Exp. defense: Fall 2026*

Awarded as joint U.S. and Czech doctoral degrees.

Dissertation: *Essays in Experimental Economics*.

Research stay at the University of Chicago: joined John List's group, Sept 2023 – Mar 2024.

Research stay at Princeton University, Oct 2023

M.A. in Economics and Econometrics, CERGE-EI, Prague (U.S. degree) 2020

M.A. in Economics, Armenian State University of Economics (ASUE), *summa cum laude* 2018

B.A. in Economics, Armenian State University of Economics (ASUE), *summa cum laude* 2016

Job Market Paper

Ambiguity and Racial Discrimination

Abstract: In this study, I ask whether ambiguity in a decision environment can provide moral cover for racial discrimination. The study is motivated by the idea that discriminatory preferences may not be expressed when people cannot easily justify acting on them. Ambiguity can provide a plausible non-discriminatory reason for biased behavior. I conducted a preregistered, incentivized experiment with 4,327 White U.S. participants who allocated real monetary bonuses to actual recipients. The experiment varied whether the ambiguously described payoff option benefited a Black recipient or a White recipient. This design enables me to distinguish between a general tendency to avoid ambiguously framed options and the selective use of ambiguity as a justification for discrimination. The results do not support the hypothesis that ambiguity provides moral cover for discrimination at the population level. Participants choose the ambiguously framed option

more often when it benefits the Black recipient than when it benefits the White recipient, the opposite of what the selective use of ambiguity against Black recipients would predict. Overall, the evidence is more consistent with a general tendency to avoid ambiguously framed options than with ambiguity serving as moral cover for racial discrimination.

Working Papers

Sexual-Orientation Discrimination and Biological Attributions: Experimental Evidence from Russia

Pre-registered online experiment with a representative sample of Russian adults, using incentivized allocation tasks. Attribution theory predicts that presenting sexual orientation as innate should reduce discrimination. Contrary to the pre-registered hypothesis, exposure to scientific evidence for biological explanations of homosexuality *increased* discriminatory behavior. In intolerant contexts, information provision may exacerbate the behavior it is intended to reduce.

Religious Identity and Sexual-Orientation Discrimination: Experimental Evidence from Russia

Online experiment ($n = 2,093$) priming religious identity before incentivized allocation decisions and LGB-related policy questions. Participants allocate significantly less to same-sex than to different-sex profiles, and more religious respondents report less policy support. The religious prime itself has no statistically robust average effect. The paper adds causal evidence to a literature that has relied largely on correlations, and delimits what this class of priming intervention can achieve.

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, Experimental Economics, Graduate (Ph.D. level), CERGE-EI	2023-2024
Experimental design and Qualtrics, including JavaScript integration. Avg. Evaluation: 4.75/5	
Instructor, Applied Statistics, Statistics, Armenia. ASUE, Armenia	2022-2024
Mentored 50+ students in applied statistics and experimental research. Avg. Evaluation: 4.79/5	

Experience

Data Scientist , Absa Technology, Prague	May 2026 – present
Observational causal inference and experimentation	
Data Analyst, Absa Technology, Prague	Sept 2024 – May 2026
Doctoral Researcher/ PhD candidate, CERGE-EI, Prague	Sept 2023 – Dec 2025
Research Assistant, CERGE-EI, Prague	Sept 2019 – Dec 2023
Student Assistant, Remote	Feb 2019 - May 2019

Conferences & Talks

Armenian Economic Association (AEA) 2026, Yerevan; AEA 2024, Yerevan; Behavioral Economics Lab Group, Chicago Booth, 2024; University of Alabama Brown Bag (invited); UChicago Economics Brown Bag, 2023; AFE 2023, UChicago; EEA-ESEM 2023, Barcelona; ESA 2023, Lyon; AEA 2023, Yerevan; IAREP-SABE 47th, Nice; IMEBESS 2023, Lisbon; RES & SES 2023, Glasgow; AEA CSQIEP, virtual; ESA 2022, Bologna; SEA 2022, Bratislava; AEA 2022, Yerevan; Teaching Economics, CERGE-EI; oTree course, UJEP; MCC Dialogues 2020, Budapest.

Grants, Fellowships and Awards

Charles University Grant Agency (GA UK) — Principal Investigator : $\approx$ EUR 33,000	2021–2023
Young Economist of the Czech Republic: 3rd Prize	2024
Stapleton Scholar, CERGE-EI	2023
GEOCEP Research Stay, University of Chicago	2023

Professional Service

Referee: American Economic Review, Journal of Political Economy, Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics, Experimental Economics

Skills

Software: Python, Stata, SQL; Qualtrics, Databricks, Git, Latex

Methods: Experimental design, causal inference, applied econometrics, survey methodology

Field and lab experiments: End-to-end study management: design and piloting, participant recruitment, IRB protocols, data cleaning and analysis.

Languages

Armenian (native); English and Russian (fluent); Czech (basic).